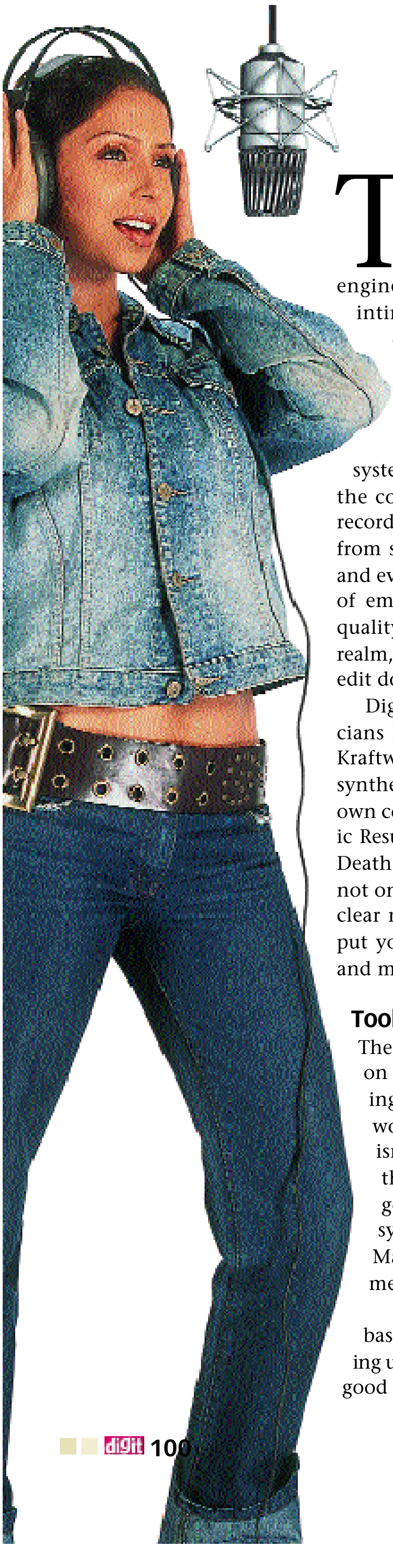
For the Love of MIC



Unleash the budding musician in you—make your own music and play it to the online world!

There was a time when producing a high-quality recording of your own music would only be possible in a recording studio, under the expertise of a sound engineering wizard who could work all those intimidating sliders, buttons and knobs. However, today, technology makes it possible to build your own home recording studio, at a fraction of the cost of professional equipment.

If you've acquired a multimedia PC system in the last few years, you already have the core setup upon which you can build your recording studio. There's a multitude of software, from sequencers to samplers to drum machines, and even full-fledged effect generators, all capable of emulating hardware audio equipment with quality. Since all editing has moved to the digital realm, you can process sound, add effects, mix and edit dozens of times without any loss in quality.

Digital music isn't a new development; musicians have used computers ever since the band Kraftwerk made its brand of techno music using synthesizers way back in the 1970s. Today, in our own country, Indi-rock musicians such as Demonic Resurrection, Pin Drop Violence and Reptilian Death use the PC to record their music demos. So not only can you use your PC to produce crystal-clear recordings of your own music, but also to put your demos on CDs, distribute them online and make good money from the airplay!

Tools of the trade

The kind of recording setup you need depends on the kind of music you are interested in making, and the instruments (if any) you will be working with. As for the right platform, there isn't a huge difference between the Mac and the PC for audio applications and you could go with either one. While some experimental synthesis tools are tailored specifically for the Mac, today's PC is more than up to the task of meeting your audio recording needs.

Your PC-based recording studio can be as basic or as sophisticated as you wish, depending upon your budget and target application. The good news is that even a minimal PC recording setup can yield superior results than the analogue setup that used to be considered 'cutting edge' not too long ago. In your base computer, a 7,200-rpm ATA-100 drive is fast enough to handle the creation of WAV files that are critical to your audio recording process. Obviously, the larger the hard disk, the greater will be the number of recordings you can store on it. Lots of RAM (256 MB at least), and a fast CPU (over 1 GHz) will boost the performance and speed, especially during the editing stage. Sequencing software need to display a lot of information on screen, so a 17-inch monitor running at a high resolution (at least 1024x768 at 75 Hz) is desirable. A CD-Writer is a must-have and writeable CDs have become downright cheap—you can expect to pay less than Rs 20 a disk. Though this is not a required component when you start off, you'll soon want one to store and distribute your music demos.

For a basic recording setup, you would have to invest in a good soundcard such as the SoundBlaster Live! Value, a microphone and powered speakers, all of which will cost you between Rs 10,000 to 15,000 (*see box, 'Professional Hardware'*). Warren Mendonsa, the lead guitarist of Zero, uses an M-Audio Audiophile 2496 soundcard, M-Audio Audio Buddy mic preamp and a Shure SM58 microphone to record his guitar solos. You will also need an outboard mixer if you plan to work with multiple microphones, since the number of microphone inputs on conventional soundcards is limited to one.

The recording process

The actual process of recording depends upon the equipment and the type of music being recorded.

SoundForge 6.0, FruityLoops 3.5, WaveLab 3.03a, BBE Sonic Maximizer, Cakewalk SONAR 2.0 Demo, ReBirth RB-338 2.0.1, Reason 2.0

on CD

Find them in Software > Multimedia on the Mindware CD. Plus, sound clips in Surge > Samples on the Playware CD for you to experiment with